

Jean-Paul Sartre

FUNDAMENTAL IDEAS

Existence Precedes Essence:

- **Concept:** Like de Beauvoir, one of the most fundamental tenets of Sartre's existentialism is the idea that "existence precedes essence." In simple terms, it means that individuals first exist, encounter themselves, and then define their essence or nature through their actions and choices.
- **Implication:** This rejects the notion of a predetermined human nature or essence. There's no fixed "human nature" since there's no God or external entity to define such a nature. Thus, individuals are responsible for creating their own essence through their choices and actions.

Radical Freedom:

- **Concept:** Sartre believed that humans are condemned to be free. There's no external force or destiny determining our actions. Every choice we make defines our essence.
- **Implication:** This freedom is both liberating and burdensome. While it allows individuals to shape their destinies, it also brings the weight of responsibility for every action and its consequences.

Bad Faith (Mauvaise foi):

- **Concept:** Sartre introduced the notion of "bad faith" as a form of self-deception. It's the act of denying one's complete freedom and responsibility by attributing one's actions to external causes or societal norms.
- **Implication:** Living in bad faith is living inauthentically. It's a way to escape the anxiety of freedom by conforming to societal expectations or attributing decisions to factors beyond one's control.

Anguish and Absurdity:

- **Concept:** Recognising one's complete freedom and the absence of any predetermined essence or moral framework leads to feelings of anguish and absurdity.
- **Implication:** The world lacks inherent meaning, and the realisation of this can lead to a sense of despair. However, it also opens the door for individuals to create their own meanings and values.

The Look and the Other:

- **Concept:** In his work "Being and Nothingness," Sartre explores the idea of "the Look." It's the awareness that others can perceive us, leading to a feeling of being objectified or defined by their perceptions.
- **Implication:** This introduces the idea that our self-awareness and identity are shaped not only by our internal perceptions but also by our interactions and relationships with others.

Commitment and Action:

- **Concept:** For Sartre, existentialism isn't just a philosophical contemplation but a call to action. Individuals should be committed to their choices and take active roles in shaping their destinies and the world around them.
- **Implication:** Authentic existence involves not just recognising one's freedom but actively engaging with the world, making choices, and taking responsibility for their outcomes.

Existential Marxism:

- **Concept:** Later in his life, Sartre attempted to reconcile existentialism with Marxism, emphasising the role of societal structures in shaping individual experiences while maintaining the core existentialist tenets of freedom and responsibility.
- **Implication:** This synthesis aimed to combine the individual freedom emphasised by existentialism with the societal critique offered by Marxism.

In essence, Jean-Paul Sartre's existentialism delves deeply into the human condition, exploring themes of freedom, responsibility, authenticity, and interpersonal relationships. It offers a profound reflection on the nature of existence, the challenges of freedom, and the quest for authentic living in a world devoid of inherent meaning.

Jean-Paul Sartre's Biography and Context:

Sartre's existentialism was deeply rooted in his life's events and the thinkers he engaged with.

Early Life:

Born in Paris in 1905, Sartre lost his father at a young age and was raised by his mother and maternal grandfather. His early years were marked by a passion for literature and philosophy.

Academic Pursuits:

Sartre studied at the École Normale Supérieure in Paris, where he formed significant friendships, most notably with Simone de Beauvoir. He was influenced by German phenomenology, especially the works of Edmund Husserl and Martin Heidegger.

World War II and Resistance:

Sartre served as a soldier during World War II and was captured by German forces in 1940. He spent around a year as a prisoner of war before being released. After his return to Paris, he became an active member of the French Resistance.

His wartime experiences, witnessing human resilience, freedom, and despair amidst oppression, deeply influenced his existentialist writings. The themes of freedom, responsibility, and action became even more pronounced in his work.

Post-War Paris:

After the war, Sartre became a central figure in the Parisian intellectual scene. He founded the influential journal "Les Temps Modernes" and engaged in various political and social issues.

His post-war writings and activism reflect a commitment to existentialist principles applied to real-world issues, emphasising individual freedom and societal responsibility.

Engagement with Other Thinkers:

Sartre's existentialism was in dialogue with other existential thinkers like Albert Camus, Friedrich Nietzsche, and Fyodor Dostoevsky. However, he had disagreements, most notably with Camus over issues like revolutionary violence.

These engagements enriched his thought, leading to both convergences and divergences with other existentialist thinkers.

Jean-Paul Sartre's Existential Philosophy:

1. Existence Precedes Essence:

Sartre's foundational claim is that existence comes before essence for humans. Unlike inanimate objects, humans are not born with a predetermined purpose or nature. Instead, they forge their essence through their choices and actions in the world.

Extended: In a world devoid of divine determination, humans are thrown into existence with the freedom to define themselves. This freedom is both a blessing and a curse: it allows for self-definition but also carries the weight of responsibility.

What we Ought to do: Sartre believed individuals ought to recognise and embrace their radical freedom. They should not hide behind societal norms or preconceived roles but instead actively define their essence through authentic choices.

2. Radical Freedom and Responsibility:

Sartre posited that humans possess an immense degree of freedom. Even in situations of external constraint, individuals retain the freedom of choice in how they respond or interpret their circumstances.

Extended: This freedom, however, is accompanied by a profound sense of responsibility. Every choice made contributes to defining one's essence and, in a broader sense, contributes to defining what it means to be human.

What we Ought to do: Individuals ought to be acutely aware of their freedom and the corresponding responsibility. They should act authentically, understanding that each action has consequences not just for oneself but for the collective definition of humanity.

3. Bad Faith (Mauvaise foi):

Bad faith is the act of self-deception, where individuals deny their freedom and responsibility, often to avoid the anxiety associated with them.

Extended: People in bad faith might attribute their actions to societal norms, their role in society, or external circumstances. By doing so, they escape the existential anguish of freedom but live inauthentically.

What we Ought to do: Sartre argued that individuals ought to confront and overcome bad faith. They should recognise and accept their freedom and the inherent responsibility, striving for authenticity even when it's uncomfortable.

4. Anguish and Absurdity:

Recognising one's freedom and the lack of inherent meaning or moral structure in the world can lead to feelings of anguish and a sense of absurdity.

Extended: The absurdity stems from the realisation that the world lacks inherent purpose, yet humans continuously seek meaning. Anguish is the emotional response to the weight of freedom and the responsibility it entails.

What we Ought to do: While these feelings are natural, Sartre believed individuals ought to confront them head-on. Instead of succumbing to despair, they should create their own meaning and values, forging purpose in an indifferent universe.

5. The Look and the Other:

Sartre explored interpersonal dynamics, emphasising how individuals become objectified in the gaze of the other. This realisation that one is being perceived can lead to feelings of objectification and alienation.

Extended: This dynamic highlights the tension between one's subjective experience and the external perception of oneself. It underscores the complexities of human relationships and the challenge of maintaining authenticity in interpersonal interactions.

What we Ought to do: Sartre suggested that individuals ought to be aware of this dynamic, striving for genuine relationships based on mutual recognition and respect, rather than reducing the other to mere objects.

6. Commitment and Action:

Beyond abstract contemplation, Sartre's existentialism is a call to committed action in the world.

Extended: In a universe devoid of preordained values, individuals have the responsibility to create values through their actions. These actions not only define the individual but also shape the world.

What we Ought to do: Sartre believed individuals ought to be actively engaged in the world. Authentic existence involves not only recognising one's freedom and responsibility but also acting on them, committedly shaping one's destiny and contributing to societal change.

At its core, Sartre's existentialism is a call to action—a call for individuals to recognise their radical freedom, confront the inherent challenges of existence, and actively shape their destinies in an ever-complex world.